we would then drive up together. All three were in their eighties, my father the eldest at eighty-eight. Coordinating their move with wheelchairs and all had been a major exercise. It had been equally difficult to convince my mother to undertake the trip. Everything went smoothly and everyone reached the airport, but then there was an unexpected delay due to a major sandstorm at Chandigarh that affected visibility. After a delay of a few hours, all the flights were cancelled and my parents returned home. This was a big disappointment; the weather in Shimla was at its best, and they would have really enjoyed their stay. After about two weeks, we decided to try again, but this time my mother point-blank refused to travel. She was convinced she had a 'jinx' because of which the flight had been cancelled. Anyway, my father and mother-in-law did come, and this time everything went off smoothly as planned. One Sunday evening, we had just finished dinner and were getting ready for bed when my sister rang up from Pune to say that my mother had suffered a heart attack and passed away. It was 22 July, and she was just a few months short of her eighty-eighth birthday. It was a shock, as I had just spoken to her that morning, giving her all the news from Shimla and all seemed well. Unfortunately, I hadn't been on leave since May, so that was the last time I saw her. I had to break the news to my father, who was so distraught that he had not been there for her final moments. The whole night he kept pacing in his room, packing all his stuff, ready to depart for Pune. I rang up the Chief and took his permission to proceed on leave and all four of us did the sombre journey to Pune. Isha and Amala also fetched up, to console me. I had always been my mother's laadka, her favourite, and it was a strange feeling that I would never see her again.

We had some fun times in Shimla too. Walks on the Ridge or through the forest trails. Of the two, the walks on the Ridge

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